SOCIAL BUTTERFLIES FOUNDATION

Moderated usability Session guide

Read-aloud script, neutral probes, intervention rules, and closing

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Session length: 35–45 minutes | Core sample: 10 prior donors | Devices: 5 mobile / 5 desktop | Tasks: T1–T4. Use with the research study plan and evidence workbook.

Before the participant joins

Confirm participant ID, device, browser, test version, access needs, session mode, and the safe pre-payment stopping point. Have fictional customization details ready (name: Alex; number: 12 only if supported). Record any task variant. Confirm the actual authorized recording viewers and retention/deletion date, then explain those details during consent. Do not begin recording before permission.

00–05 minutes / Welcome and consent

"Hi, I'm De'Andre. Thanks for joining. We're looking at how the SBF apparel store works. We're testing the website, not you. There are no right or wrong answers, and honest feedback helps us understand the experience."

"This session should take about 35–45 minutes. You'll try four shopping activities. You won't need to buy anything, enter payment information, or share health information. Use the fictional details I provide. You can skip a question, take a break, or stop at any time."

"I'll take notes using a participant code instead of your name. Before we start, I'll explain who can see the notes and any recording, how we may use anonymized excerpts, and when the information will be deleted. Do you have any questions? Do you agree to participate?"

After explaining the actual recording arrangements: "May I record your screen and audio to help us review what happens? It is okay to say no; we can continue with notes." Record participation consent and recording choice separately. If either permission changes, stop the relevant activity and document the request.

05–08 minutes / Background

"Tell me about the last time you bought clothing or accessories online."
"What information mattered before you decided to buy?"
"If you have purchased a personalized item, tell me about that experience."
"What device or setup do you usually use?"

02 / Think-aloud and first tasks

08–10 minutes / Explain think-aloud

“As you use the site, please say what you’re looking for, what you notice, and what you expect to happen. I may stay quiet so I don’t influence your choices. If I ask what you’re thinking, I’m interested in your experience; it does not mean you did something wrong.”

“Please use your usual access method. Do you need any adjustment before we begin?” Confirm screen sharing if remote. If useful, practice think-aloud briefly on an unrelated activity; do not demonstrate the shopping path.

10–15 minutes / T1: Find apparel

READ: “You want a personalized apparel item as a gift to support SBF. Find an item you would consider buying.”

START: Store homepage in the assigned test version.
SUCCESS: Eligible customizable product page reached without directional help.
OBSERVE: First action, category/search choices, backtracking, errors, and participant explanation. Do not say which collection to use.

AFTER: “What led you to choose this item?” Then ask the standard ratings on page 3. If they cannot find an eligible item, record T1 first and open the prepared product page for T2. Log the reset.

15–21 minutes / T2: Personalize

READ: “Set up this item using the fictional details provided. Tell me when it is ready to add to your cart.”

PROVIDE: Alex as the name; number 12 only when the product supports it. Let participants choose other supported options. Use equivalent requirements for every participant; log any product or task variation.
SUCCESS: Required options and personalization are correct and saved.
OBSERVE: Field comprehension, errors, confirmation feedback, repeated checks, and ability to edit.

AFTER: “Tell me what you expect to receive.” Ask the standard ratings. If needed, record the outcome before preparing a correctly configured item for the next task; log the reset. Do not reveal a saving problem before the participant encounters it.

03 / Delivery, review, and ratings

21–26 minutes / T3: Delivery information

READ: “Before deciding to buy, find out when you could expect this item to arrive.”

START: The selected product page.
SUCCESS: Applicable production/shipping information found and accurately explained, including uncertainty if no exact date is available.
OBSERVE: Where they look, interpretation of production versus transit time, missing information, and help requests.

AFTER: “Based on what you found, what would you expect?” Ask the standard ratings. Explore returns or nonprofit mission information only after the scored task, as optional probes; do not combine them with the delivery completion count.

26–32 minutes / T4: Review order

READ: “Add the item to your cart and review the order as you normally would. Tell me whether you would proceed and why. Stop before payment.”

START: Correctly configured product; log any moderator setup.
SUCCESS: Available pre-payment review reached; participant checks item, options, personalization, and costs, and identifies any cost still unavailable.
OBSERVE: Errors, corrections, unexpected totals, missing summaries, and stopping points. Do not require a purchase or expose payment data.

AFTER: “Tell me what this order includes and what you expect to pay.” Ask the standard ratings. A participant may meet the review criterion and still decide not to buy; record willingness to purchase separately.

After every task / Ask the same ratings

EASE: “Overall, how easy or difficult was that task?”
1 = Very difficult; 7 = Very easy. Offer all seven response choices.
CONFIDENCE: “How confident are you that you completed that task correctly?”
1 = Not at all confident; 5 = Very confident. Offer all five response choices.

First record the behavioral outcome and stop timing; then ask ratings. Record missing ratings as missing. Do not substitute a rating for observed completion. Use open follow-ups after the participant answers: “What influenced that rating?”

04 / Facilitation rules and closing

When someone pauses or gets stuck

Situation	Moderator response / coding
Brief pause or exploration	Wait without interrupting. Note behavior; do not infer confusion solely from silence.
Participant stops thinking aloud	“What are you thinking about right now?” Neutral reminders alone do not change I to A.
Participant asks where to click	“What would you try if I weren’t here?” If they continue unaided, retain independent eligibility.
Participant asks what the task means	Repeat the scenario without revealing the path. Log any clarification that changes the task.
No progress after neutral probing	At about 2 minutes without progress, ask: “Would you like to keep trying or move on?” End at about 5 minutes per task unless they are making progress and wish to continue; log extensions.
Participant gives up or needs direction	Record N before moving on. If continuing with an explicit hint, log the hint and final A outcome; do not label it independent.
Technical failure or distress	Pause immediately. Offer a break or stop. Code technical invalidity X, with reason; do not attribute it to usability.

Neutral probes

Use: “What were you expecting?” “What did you notice?” “What led you to do that?” “What would you try next?”
Avoid: “Was the button confusing?” “Did you see the shipping link?” “That was easy, right?” Avoid praise that signals a correct path.

32–40 minutes / Closing

“Which part, if any, took more effort than you expected?”
“What information, if anything, was missing?”
“What would you change first, and why?”
“Is there anything else you would like us to know?”
“Thank you. Your feedback will help us decide what to improve.”

Reserve remaining time, up to 45 minutes, for setup, access needs, and questions. Confirm whether the participant has any data-use questions. Stop recording, check notes, and separate observation from interpretation immediately after the session. Record actual session duration and deviations.